

The 10-Minute Food Delivery Puzzle

Why Zomato Failed Repeatedly and Swiggy Didn't — A Research Base

Prepared for: Deck construction **Data current as of:** 25 August 2026 **Latest financials used:** Swiggy Q4FY26 (audited, 8 May 2026) · Eternal Q1FY27 (22 July 2026)

0. How to use this document — read this first

This is a **base document**, not a deck. It contains more than you will use. That is intentional: you should be able to answer any question a reviewer throws at you, including ones your slides don't cover.

Three things I want you to internalise before you build slides:

1. **Your original problem statement has a flaw, and fixing it makes your project much stronger.** I've handled this in Section 1. Don't skip it.
2. **Every number here has a source.** Section 11 is the source list. If a number isn't sourced, I've flagged it as contested. Never put an unsourced number on a slide.
3. **Section 10 lists what I could not verify and where sources conflict.** A good analyst leads with their uncertainties. A weak one hides them. Put one slide on this near the end — it will read as rigour, not weakness.

I've written PM commentary in blockquotes throughout, like this:

PM note: This is where I explain the *decision logic* — what a product manager would actually be weighing, not just what happened.

1. The problem statement needs one correction — and it's the most valuable thing in this project

What you asked

"Why did Zomato fail three times at 10-minute food delivery while Swiggy made the same idea work?"

What the evidence actually shows

The "three failures" holds up. Zomato/Eternal shut down three quick-food initiatives:

#	Product	Launched	Shut down	Lifespan
1	Zomato Instant	March 2022	January 2023	~10 months
2	Zomato Everyday	2023 (replaced Instant)	May 2025	~2 years
3	Zomato Quick	January 2025	May 2025	~3–4 months

But **two premises in your question are wrong**, and correcting them is where your project earns its marks:

Wrong premise #1: "the same idea." These were not the same idea. Under the label "10-minute food delivery" sit **three structurally different business models** with completely different cost structures. Zomato and Swiggy were not running the same experiment. (Full taxonomy in Section 3.)

Wrong premise #2: "Swiggy made it work." Swiggy succeeded at *one* model (Bolt) and **failed at another one in the same year** — Swiggy shut down **Snacc**, its own 10-minute owned-kitchen app, during Q4FY26 (Jan–Mar 2026). And Eternal is now succeeding, cautiously, at the model Swiggy failed at (**Bistro by Blinkit**).

The corrected problem statement

"Three of the four architectures for 10-minute food delivery have failed for both players. Why did the marketplace-filter model succeed only for Swiggy — and why is the owned-kitchen model now succeeding only for Eternal?"

PM note: This is the single most important move in the whole project. Any classmate can narrate "Zomato failed, Swiggy won." Almost nobody will notice that **Swiggy also failed at 10-minute food delivery**, that Zepto retreated too, and that Eternal may be winning the *next* round. The scoreboard is not settled. A deck that says "Swiggy won" in August 2026 is a deck that will be out of date by December. Frame it as an unresolved architectural question and your analysis stays true.

2. The verified fact base

2.1 Zomato / Eternal — attempt by attempt

Attempt 1: Zomato Instant (March 2022 – January 2023)

- **Announced:** 21 March 2022 by CEO Deepinder Goyal on LinkedIn/Twitter. Launched as a pilot in Gurugram.
- **The model:** A network of dedicated "**finishing stations**" — company-operated facilities placed near high-demand neighbourhoods, each stocking roughly **20–30 best-selling dishes** from partner restaurants, selected by demand-prediction algorithms. Goyal's announcement also referenced "future-ready in-station robotics."
- **Scale reached:** Approximately **5 finishing stations**, mostly in NCR, later extended to Bengaluru. This is small — worth stressing on a slide.
- **Goyal's framing at launch:** He claimed nobody worldwide had delivered hot, fresh food in under 10 minutes at scale, and that Zomato was eager to be first to create the category globally.
- **The safety design:** Delivery partners would not be told which orders were 10-minute orders; no penalties for lateness; no incentives for speed. Goyal's argument was that time optimisation happens in the supply chain, not on the road.
- **The backlash:** Immediate and severe. Criticism centred on rider road-safety in Indian traffic conditions and on food quality compromises. A Member of Parliament publicly objected and raised it in Parliament. The **Fairwork India** gig-economy ratings had scored Zomato **zero points for three consecutive years through 2021** on "Fair Conditions: Mitigates task-specific risks" — which undercut Zomato's safety assurances in the public debate.
- **Analyst scepticism at launch:** Bernstein analysts and many investors argued 10-minute *grocery* delivery already didn't make economic sense; food — where you cannot pre-stock finished inventory in a dark store — would be harder still.
- **The end:** Media reported in January 2023 that Instant was discontinued because it had struggled to grow and faced a difficult path to profitability. **Zomato denied a shutdown**, saying it was a rebrand: the service was being re-menue'd with partners, all finishing stations remained intact, and no staff were affected. It re-emerged as Zomato Everyday.

PM note on the denial: Do not treat "we're rebranding, not shutting down" as a fact — treat it as a *company position* and label it as such. The verifiable facts are: the 10-minute promise disappeared from the app, and the product was renamed and repositioned. Present both the company's claim and the media reporting, and let the reader judge. Never assert a motive you can't source.

Attempt 2: Zomato Everyday (2023 – May 2025)

- **The model:** Home-style, everyday meals rather than restaurant dishes, at similar fast delivery timelines. Effectively a repositioning of the Instant infrastructure toward a different job-to-be-done.
- **The end:** Shut down alongside Quick in **May 2025**. Goyal's stated reason: *the need for homely meals is a limited use case, largely confined to office locations in metros*. In other words — the demand was real but the addressable market was too narrow to justify the infrastructure.

Attempt 3: Zomato Quick (January 2025 – May 2025)

- **Launched:** Pilots began in NCR in late January / early February 2025. Zomato emailed restaurant partners to onboard them, **starting with restaurants that had consistent ratings on hygiene, kitchen prep time and quality** (confirmed by Kawaljeet Singh, CEO of Harsukh Foods, which operates 50+ NCR outlets).
- **The model:** Ready-to-eat dishes from *existing partner restaurants*, delivered within a **1.5–2 km radius**. Note: this is essentially the **same architecture as Swiggy Bolt**, launched three months later.
- **Positioning at launch:** Explicitly framed by the market as Zomato's answer to Swiggy Bolt, alongside Bistro by Blinkit, Zepto Café, and Zing.
- **Advance warning signal:** In an October 2024 Moneycontrol interview — *before Quick even launched* — Goyal said finding restaurant partners was proving difficult. CFO Akshant Goyal separately downplayed these initiatives as early-stage and unlikely to move the needle on core food delivery.
- **The end (1 May 2025) — three direct quotes worth putting on a slide:**
 - *"We are shutting down both these initiatives as we are not seeing the path to profitability in these without compromising on customer experience."*
 - *"The current restaurant density & kitchen infrastructure is not set up for delivering orders in 10 minutes which leads to inconsistent customer experience."*
 - *"We did not see any incrementality in demand while we ran Quick as an experiment for a few months."*

PM note: That third quote is the crux of your entire project. Hold onto it — Section 6 is built on it. Zomato ran essentially the same product as Bolt and concluded there was **no incremental demand**. Swiggy ran it and concluded it drove **higher-retention new users**. Two competent teams, similar product, opposite verdicts. That divergence is your thesis.

Attempt 4 (ongoing): Bistro by Blinkit — the one that's working

- **Launched:** December 2024, as a **standalone app**, separate from both Zomato and Blinkit.
- **The model:** Meals prepared fresh in **micro-kitchens embedded inside Blinkit's existing dark stores**. Because the food is already at the delivery hub rather than at a separate restaurant, order-to-door time collapses. Blinkit's existing rider fleet handles last mile. Menu is deliberately canteen-style — quick lunch, mid-afternoon snack, early

dinner — not restaurant dishes. Pricing deliberately undercuts traditional food delivery. No restaurant commissions in the cost stack.

- **Scale: 38 kitchens** across Bengaluru and Delhi-NCR as of the Q1FY26 shareholder letter (July 2025). By Q1FY27 (July 2026), management said it is expanding **cautiously at roughly 10 kitchens per quarter**, with older kitchens showing strong throughput. Coverage as of early 2026: select neighbourhoods of Gurugram, Delhi-NCR, Noida and Bengaluru.
- **Corporate signal:** Eternal incorporated a wholly-owned subsidiary, **Blinkit Foods** (August 2025), to house the food-services vertical under the Bistro brand. Proposed authorised share capital ₹1 crore.
- **Early results claim (Q1FY26 letter):** Kitchens are generating **incremental orders without cannibalising Zomato's existing business**.
- **Cost:** Eternal management confirmed on the Q2FY26 call that most of the losses in the relevant segment were attributable to Bistro expansion.
- **The strategic framing (Q1FY27 shareholder letter, July 2026)** — the single best quote in the entire dataset:

"We're rethinking kitchen operations from first principles – designing custom equipment, workflows, and automation purpose-built for high-volume, limited-menu formats. This isn't a restaurant. It's closer to a food manufacturing system optimised for freshness, speed, and consistency. It's a different segment, a different occasion, and a genuinely new market."

- Management also argued it would be **impossible for any platform to make food delivery work at ₹50–150 price points without supply-chain innovation** — a direct shot at the marketplace-filter model.

The newest experiment: Zomato Now (August 2026)

Eternal is piloting **food vending pods in Gurugram corporate offices** in partnership with restaurant partners. Very early; treat as a footnote, not a finding. But it tells you Eternal has still not stopped searching for the right architecture.

2.2 Swiggy — Bolt, and the failure nobody talks about

Bolt (October 2024 – present) — the success

- **Launched:** 5 October 2024, one month before Swiggy's IPO (listed 13 November 2024).
- **The model — memorise these three design constraints:**
 1. **Only dishes requiring minimal-to-zero preparation** — burgers, hot and cold beverages, breakfast items, biryani, plus ready-to-pack snacks, chocolates, ice cream.

2. **Delivery radius hard-capped at 2 km.**
 3. **Restaurants selected for proven fast order turnaround** — no new infrastructure built.
- **Rider safety design:** Delivery partners are **not told** whether an order is Bolt or regular. They are neither penalised nor incentivised on delivery time. *(Note: this is the identical design Zomato announced for Instant in 2022 and was attacked for. Swiggy shipped it in 2024 with negligible backlash. Timing of public narrative — see Section 6.)*
 - **Launch quote (Rohit Kapoor, CEO Swiggy Food Marketplace):** Ten years ago Swiggy revolutionised food delivery by cutting waits to 30 minutes; Bolt reduces that wait further for frequent occasions.

Scaling trajectory:

Date	Cities	Restaurants	Share of food delivery
5 Oct 2024 (launch)	6 metros	2,700	—
2 Dec 2024	400+	40,000+ (10 lakh+ items)	—
Q3FY25 (Oct–Dec 24)	400+	—	9% of food deliveries
Q4FY25 (Jan–Mar 25)	—	—	12%+ of FD GOV
May 2025	500+	45,000+ brands	—
Nov 2025	700+	—	~1 in 10 orders
June 2026	700+	—	<i>not separately disclosed</i>

- **The two numbers that justify Bolt's existence:**
 - **New users acquired through Bolt show 4–6% higher monthly retention than the platform average.** (Swiggy management, Q4FY25; corroborated by HSIE and Motilal Oswal analyst notes.)
 - **Bolt is not margin-dilutive.** JM Financial's assessment: the slightly lower AOV is offset by lower cost of delivery, because the radius is capped at 2 km. *This is the whole ballgame — see Section 4.*
- **Market impact at launch:** Swiggy shares rose 9.4% and hit an all-time high of ₹542.10 on the day the 400-city expansion was announced.
- **Current disclosure (Q4FY26, May 2026):** Swiggy no longer breaks out Bolt separately. It now reports that **Bolt, One BLCK, 99-Store and Eat Right collectively account for approximately one-fourth of total platform volumes.** Management explicitly credits these propositions with shifting the value proposition **"from discount-led to utility-led."**

Snacc (January 2025 – Q4FY26) — Swiggy's failure

This is the finding that most projects will miss.

- **What it was:** A **standalone 15-minute app** delivering meals, drinks and small bites from **Swiggy's own micro-kitchens**. Launched January 2025 in select Bengaluru pin codes, later Noida and Gurugram. Menu: fruit bowls, tea, coffee, breakfast specials, snacks, cold beverages.
- **The end:** Shut down during **Q4FY26** (Jan–Mar 2026). Swiggy's Q4FY26 shareholder letter states it plainly:

"We launched, tested, and shut down Snacc within the fiscal year. The micro-kitchen model requires a high density of demand in micro markets to operate on sustainable economics. We proactively shut down Snacc during the quarter as we were not convinced on the steady state size of the category for the incremental complexity involved to run the business."

PM note: Put this quote next to Goyal's Quick quote on a single slide. Read them together:

- **Zomato on the marketplace-filter model:** *"restaurant density & kitchen infrastructure is not set up for 10 minutes."*
- **Swiggy on the owned-kitchen model:** *"requires a high density of demand in micro markets to operate on sustainable economics."*

Both companies failed. Both cited **density** as the binding constraint. They just hit it on opposite sides of the supply chain. That symmetry is the most elegant slide in your deck.

2.3 The rest of the field — proving this is structural, not a Zomato problem

Zepto Café (owned micro-kitchens inside Zepto dark stores):

- **Peak:** CEO Aadit Palicha announced on LinkedIn in **February 2025** that Café had hit **100,000 orders per day**, near a \$100M annualised GMV run-rate with claimed ~50% steady-state gross margin. One report put peak volumes at 120,000–130,000/day.
- **Retreat:** Volumes fell to **65,000–67,000/day in May–June 2025** — roughly half of peak. Zepto shut Café at **44 of its ~1,000 dark store locations** in May 2025, affecting 400+ employees, concentrated in North India.
- **Stated causes:** supply-chain bottlenecks, a **shortage of trained kitchen staff**, and a broader push to cut cash burn. Zepto also slowed new dark-store launches.
- **Company's counter-position:** A Zepto spokesperson maintained Café volumes had grown 700% YoY and 15%+ MoM with ₹1,000 crore in annual net sales, and that they

were "doubling down." *This directly contradicts the reported order decline — flag it, don't resolve it.*

Other entrants: Bistro by Blinkit, Zing, and Swish (Bengaluru startup, raised \$2M seed led by Accel) all entered the space. Ola trialled 10-minute food in Bengaluru; food-tech startup Voosh followed. Amazon India moved on 15-minute delivery in Bengaluru (December 2024). New affordability-led entrants Rapido **Ownly** and Swiggy **Toing** arrived in 2026. Flipkart was reported in mid-2026 to be preparing a food delivery launch.

PM note: Use this section to kill the lazy conclusion. If your deck implies "Zomato was badly run," the Zepto and Snacc data proves you wrong. Three well-capitalised, operationally excellent companies retreated from the owned-kitchen model within about twelve months of each other. That is not incompetence — that is a **structural constraint**. Finding the constraint is the job.

3. The architecture taxonomy — the core analytical frame of your deck

Everything makes sense once you stop treating "10-minute food delivery" as one thing. There are **four distinct architectures**:

	Model A: Dedicated finishing station	Model B: Marketplace filter	Model C: Owned micro-kitchen (standalone)	Model D: Owned micro-kitchen (piggybacked)
How it works	New company-run stations hold pre-finished restaurant dishes near demand clusters	Filter existing restaurant menus for fast-prep items; cap radius at 2 km	Build and staff your own kitchens; own the menu	Embed kitchens inside dark stores that already exist and are already paid for by grocery
Who owns the food	Restaurant (finished by platform)	Restaurant	Platform	Platform
New fixed cost created	High — per station, per micro-market	~Zero	High — per kitchen, per micro-market	Marginal — kitchen is an add-on to existing real estate + fleet

Menu control	Partial	None	Total	Total
Attempts	Zomato Instant	Swiggy Bolt ✓ · Zomato Quick ✗	Swiggy Snacc ✗ · Zepto Café ✗	Blinkit Bistro ✓ (early)
Outcome	Failed	1 success, 1 failure	Both failed	Working so far

PM note — how to read this table: The column that matters is "**new fixed cost created.**" Every model that manufactured a new fixed cost per micro-market has failed or retreated, *except* the one where the fixed cost was already sunk for a different business (Model D). The one model that created no new fixed cost at all (Model B) scaled to 700+ cities in thirteen months.

This is the load-bearing insight. If your deck communicates one thing, make it this.

4. The economics — why the architecture determines the outcome

4.1 The unit economics identity

For any delivery order:

Contribution per order = (AOV × take rate) + ad revenue
 – cost of delivery
 – platform-funded discounts
 – fulfilment/kitchen cost (Models A, C, D only)

A 10-minute product **structurally lowers AOV** — the qualifying items are burgers, coffees, snacks, single-serve meals, ₹50–150 price points. That shrinks the first term.

So a 10-minute product can only work if it **shrinks something on the cost side by more than it shrinks revenue**. There are exactly two ways to do that:

Path 1 — Shrink the delivery cost (Model B / Bolt). Capping the radius at 2 km cuts distance travelled per order and raises orders-per-rider-hour. JM Financial's conclusion: the lower AOV is offset by the lower cost of delivery, making Bolt **non-dilutive at the margin level**. No new fixed cost is created, so there is no break-even hurdle to clear — the product is margin-neutral **from order one**.

Path 2 — Eliminate the restaurant's margin (Models C/D — Bistro, Snacc, Café). Owning the kitchen removes restaurant commission economics entirely and gives full menu control, allowing genuinely low price points. Eternal's management argument is exactly this: ₹50–150 food delivery is impossible without owning the supply chain. **But this path creates a fixed cost per micro-market that must be amortised over local order density.**

4.2 Why Path 2 kept failing — and where it works

A micro-kitchen serving a 2 km radius must cover its rent, equipment and *trained kitchen staff* from orders originating inside that radius alone. There is no cross-subsidy from other geographies. So:

Break-even order density per micro-market is the single binding variable.

Three independent confirmations that this is the constraint:

Source	Quote / finding
Swiggy (Snacc, Q4FY26)	"The micro-kitchen model requires a high density of demand in micro markets to operate on sustainable economics."
Eternal (Quick, May 2025)	"The current restaurant density & kitchen infrastructure is not set up for delivering orders in 10 minutes."
Zepto (Café, 2025)	Retreat driven by supply-chain bottlenecks and a shortage of trained kitchen staff — i.e. the variable cost of running kitchens at density

So why does Bistro work? Because Blinkit had already solved the density problem for a *different* business. By Q3FY26 Blinkit operated **2,027 dark stores**, and Blinkit turned **adjusted-EBITDA positive** in Q3FY26 (₹4 crore, versus a ₹156 crore loss the previous quarter). Those locations were sited, leased, staffed and rider-served on grocery economics. A Bistro kitchen inside one is a **marginal** cost against a fixed base someone else already paid for — and it inherits the grocery order density on day one.

Swiggy's Snacc had no such base. Swiggy has 1,143 Instamart dark stores across 129 cities at ~40% capacity utilisation — but Snacc was launched as a **standalone app** with its own micro-kitchens rather than as a layer on Instamart infrastructure.

PM note — the decision this teaches: When you're asked to build a speed product, the first question is never "can we do it in 10 minutes?" It's "**what fixed cost does this create, and who is already paying for it?**" Bistro succeeded because Eternal answered "the grocery business is." Snacc failed because the answer was "nobody." Same idea, same year, same country, opposite outcomes — the difference is entirely in the balance sheet, not the product.

5. Root-cause analysis, attempt by attempt

For each failure: what actually killed it, ranked from primary to contributing.

Zomato Instant (2022)

Rank	Cause	Evidence
1	Architecture created new fixed cost with no demand base	Only ~5 finishing stations ever operated. Each needed local density it never reached.
2	Market timing — roughly 30 months too early	Announced March 2022, when 10-minute grocery was itself nascent and contested. Bernstein and investors were publicly arguing 10-min grocery didn't work; food was seen as strictly harder.
3	Public-narrative failure	Immediate rider-safety backlash, Parliamentary criticism. Fairwork's zero score for Zomato on task-risk mitigation, three years running, destroyed the credibility of the safety design.
4	Menu physics	Only a narrow set of dishes can be genuinely prepared and served in 10 minutes; the prep window is 1–2 minutes, leaving 7–8 for delivery. Anything reheated risks quality rejection.
5	Distraction / capital reallocation	The Blinkit acquisition agreement was reached days after the Instant announcement; group attention and capital moved to quick commerce.

Zomato Everyday (2023–2025)

Rank	Cause	Evidence
1	TAM too narrow	Goyal: the need for homely meals is " <i>a limited use case largely for office locations in metros.</i> " The demand was real but geographically and occasionally confined.
2	Inherited the wrong cost base	Built on Instant's finishing-station infrastructure — a repositioning of the product, not a re-architecture of the economics.

Zomato Quick (2025)

Rank	Cause	Evidence
1	Supply-side lock-out — arrived 3 months after Bolt	Bolt had 40,000+ restaurants by December 2024; Quick was cold-emailing NCR partners in late January 2025. Goyal had already flagged in October 2024 that partner acquisition was difficult.
2	No incremental demand — measured against a leader's bar	<i>"We did not see any incrementality in demand."</i> See Section 6 — this is a measurement choice as much as a market fact.
3	A better internal option existed	Bistro launched December 2024, a month before Quick's pilot. Eternal could kill Quick without exiting the category. Swiggy had no equivalent fallback in food.
4	Execution inconsistency	<i>"...leads to inconsistent customer experience"</i> — Zomato judged that hitting 10 minutes reliably through third-party kitchens it did not control was not achievable at acceptable quality.

Swiggy Snacc (2025–2026)

Rank	Cause	Evidence
1	Micro-market density below break-even	Swiggy's own stated reason, verbatim.
2	Standalone-app distribution penalty	Launched as its own app rather than inside Swiggy's ~25M-MTU platform, forcing it to acquire users from zero.
3	Complexity vs. category size	<i>"...not convinced on the steady state size of the category for the incremental complexity involved."</i> This is a portfolio judgement, not an operational one — they could run it, they chose not to.

Zepto Café (2024–2025)

Rank	Cause	Evidence
1	Kitchen labour supply	Shortage of trained kitchen staff — a constraint that scales linearly with locations and cannot be automated away quickly.

2	Cash-burn discipline	Retreat coincided with a broad push to reduce burn; dark-store launches slowed simultaneously.
3	Freshness/quality control at speed	Reported difficulty maintaining consistent quality and real-time delivery of ready-to-consume items.

6. The central question: same model, opposite verdicts

Zomato Quick and Swiggy Bolt were, architecturally, **the same product**. Fast-prep items from existing restaurant partners, ~2 km radius, no new infrastructure. Bolt scaled to 700+ cities. Quick died in three months.

Here are the five explanations, ranked by strength of evidence. Your deck should present at least the top three.

Explanation 1 — Timing and supply lock-in (*strong evidence*)

Bolt launched **5 October 2024**. Quick piloted **late January 2025**. That is a ~16-week head start.

In those 16 weeks Bolt went from **2,700 to 40,000+ restaurants**. When Zomato approached restaurants in January, it was asking partners to redo operational work they had already done for a competitor — new SLAs, new menu curation, new prep-time commitments — for a second, smaller, unproven channel.

This is a classic **two-sided marketplace land-grab**. The supply side has finite integration bandwidth. First mover doesn't just get share; it gets the *partner's willingness to change how they operate*, which is a one-time asset.

PM note: Note that Zomato was still the **market leader** in food delivery throughout, with **58%+ GOV share** in Q1FY27 and ~40% more MTUs than Swiggy. Leadership on the demand side did **not** protect it on the supply side. Supply-side lock-in is a separate, independently contestable resource. That's a genuinely non-obvious strategic lesson and worth a slide of its own.

Explanation 2 — Different success metrics produced different verdicts (*strong evidence — this is your thesis*)

The two companies **measured the same product against different bars**:

Zomato / Quick

Swiggy / Bolt

Question asked	Is this demand incremental , or cannibalising our existing orders?	Does this acquire and retain new users ?
Answer found	<i>"We did not see any incrementality in demand."</i>	New users via Bolt retain 4–6% better than platform average.
Margin test	No path to profitability <i>without compromising customer experience</i> .	Non-dilutive — lower AOV offset by lower delivery cost.
Verdict	Kill it	Scale it nationally

Why the different bars? **Because they were in different strategic positions.**

- **Zomato was the incumbent leader:** 58%+ GOV share, food delivery already profitable, optimising for margin and AOV. For a leader, a low-AOV product that shifts existing orders is **value-destructive** — you cannibalise a ₹400 order into a ₹200 order and lose the difference. The incrementality test is the *correct* test for a leader.
- **Swiggy was the challenger, and had just IPO'd** (13 November 2024, five weeks after Bolt's launch). It needed a growth narrative, a differentiation story, and new users. For a challenger, a margin-neutral product that acquires better-retaining users is **strongly value-creative even if some orders are cannibalised** — because the strategic prize is share, not per-order margin.

PM note — the lesson to put on your final slide: *The same data can produce opposite, and both correct, product decisions depending on the company's strategic position.* Zomato didn't measure wrong. Swiggy didn't get lucky. They ran different experiments because they were playing different games. When you kill or greenlight a feature as a PM, the metric you choose is not a neutral technical decision — it encodes your company's strategy. **Choosing the metric is the strategic act.**

Explanation 3 — Portfolio substitution: Zomato had somewhere better to put the money (*strong evidence*)

Quick was killed on 1 May 2025. Bistro had launched in December 2024 and was already showing what Eternal described as encouraging early data — incremental orders without cannibalising Zomato.

So Zomato was not choosing between "Quick" and "no 10-minute food." It was choosing between **Quick (Model B, low control, no incrementality)** and **Bistro (Model D, full control, riding Blinkit's paid-for density)**. It reallocated.

The strongest confirmation of this came nine months later: on 1 February 2026, Deepinder Goyal stepped down as Eternal Group CEO, and **Albinder Dhindsa — founder and CEO of Blinkit — became Group CEO**. Goyal moved to Vice Chairman. In his shareholder letter, Goyal

wrote that Blinkit would remain Dhindsa's top priority and that Blinkit's journey from acquisition to breakeven happened under Dhindsa's leadership.

PM note: A CEO transition is the loudest signal a public company can send about where it believes value lives. Eternal handed the whole group to the quick-commerce founder. Read alongside the Bistro strategy — *"this isn't a restaurant, it's closer to a food manufacturing system"* — the message is that Eternal has concluded **fast food delivery is a supply-chain problem, not a marketplace problem**. That is a genuinely different bet from Swiggy's. Your deck should end on this open question, not on a winner.

Explanation 4 — Public-narrative timing and accumulated brand scar tissue (*moderate evidence*)

Compare the two launches:

	Zomato Instant, March 2022	Swiggy Bolt, October 2024
Rider safety design	Riders not told which orders are 10-min; no penalties; no speed incentives	Identical design
Public reaction	Severe backlash; Parliamentary criticism; CEO forced into defensive follow-up posts	Negligible backlash; stock hit an all-time high on expansion news

The design was the same. The reception was opposite. Two plausible reasons: (a) by late 2024 the Indian consumer had been conditioned by three years of 10-minute *grocery* from Blinkit, Instamart and Zepto, so 10-minute delivery no longer read as reckless; (b) Zomato specifically carried reputational baggage — the Fairwork zero-scores gave critics a concrete, citable counter to its safety claims.

PM note — caution: Reception is hard to measure rigorously. I could not find a quantified sentiment comparison between the two launches. Present this as a **qualitative observation supported by the contrast in coverage**, not as a measured finding. If a reviewer pushes you, say exactly that. That's the honest answer and it's a better answer than overclaiming.

Explanation 5 — Market readiness (*moderate evidence*)

India's quick-commerce market grew more than **100% in the year to end-2024**. The instant-delivery market was valued at roughly **\$11.5 billion** by early 2026. Zomato Instant launched into a market that did not yet exist in habit terms; Bolt launched into one that did.

PM note: Be careful not to lean too hard on this. It explains Instant (2022) well. It does **not** explain Quick (2025), which launched into the *same* mature market as Bolt, three months later, and still failed. Timing is a necessary but insufficient

explanation. Any classmate who stops at "Zomato was too early" has only explained one of three failures.

7. The thesis — three causal claims

Your conclusion should be a small number of defensible claims, each with evidence. Not a list of differences.

Claim 1: Architecture, not ambition, determined the outcome.

Every model that created a **new fixed cost per micro-market** failed or retreated — Zomato Instant, Zomato Quick, Swiggy Snacc, Zepto Café. The only two survivors created **no new fixed cost** (Bolt) or **piggybacked on a fixed cost already paid for by another business** (Bistro on Blinkit's 2,027 dark stores).

Evidence: Swiggy's Snacc post-mortem, Goyal's Quick post-mortem, and Zepto's Café retreat all independently name **density** as the binding constraint. JM Financial's finding that Bolt is margin non-dilutive because of the 2 km cap.

Claim 2: A 16-week head start compounded into an unassailable supply position.

Bolt's October–December 2024 window took it from 2,700 to 40,000+ restaurants before Quick's pilot began. In a two-sided marketplace, supply-side integration bandwidth is finite and first-mover-takes-it. Market leadership on the demand side (Zomato's 58%+ GOV share) did not transfer to the supply side.

Evidence: Onboarding timelines; Goyal's October 2024 admission that partner acquisition was difficult; the Harsukh Foods account of Zomato's January 2025 outreach.

Claim 3: The metric each company chose encoded its strategy — and produced opposite verdicts on near-identical products.

Zomato tested for **incrementality** (the right test for a margin-optimising leader) and found none. Swiggy tested for **new-user acquisition and retention** (the right test for a share-seeking challenger, five weeks post-IPO) and found +4–6% retention. Neither was wrong.

Evidence: Goyal's incrementality quote vs. Swiggy's retention disclosure and JM Financial's margin assessment; the divergent strategic positions (58% share and profitable vs. challenger and newly listed).

The corollary — do not declare a winner

As of August 2026:

- **Swiggy's** speed-and-affordability propositions (Bolt, One BLCK, 99-Store, Eat Right) are ~**25% of platform volumes**, food delivery GOV grew **22.6% YoY** to ₹9,005 crore — a 15-quarter high — and food delivery adjusted EBITDA margin hit a lifetime high of **3.3%**. But Swiggy **shut down its own micro-kitchen bet**.
- **Eternal** retains **58%+ GOV share**, generates **2:1** more food-delivery EBITDA, and is scaling Bistro at ~10 kitchens per quarter under a CEO who came from quick commerce. But Swiggy's food-delivery EBITDA grew **5x over nine quarters** against Eternal's 2x.

Two companies, two opposite architectural bets, both currently working. **That is your closing slide.**

8. Frameworks worth naming in the deck

Use two or three, not all five. Naming a framework you don't use is worse than using one you don't name.

1. **Fixed-cost absorption / asset-light vs. asset-heavy.** The central lens. Who pays the fixed cost, and is it already sunk?
 2. **Unit economics decomposition.** $\text{Contribution} = \text{revenue per order} - \text{delivery cost} - \text{discounts} - \text{fulfilment cost}$. Shows why a low-AOV product can still be accretive if it cuts the cost side harder.
 3. **Jobs-to-be-Done.** Eternal's Bistro framing is textbook JTBD: *"a different segment, a different occasion, and a genuinely new market."* 10-minute food is not "dinner, faster." It's a snack/single-serve occasion at ₹50–150 that barely overlaps with the ₹400 dinner order. Misdiagnosing it as the same job is what makes cannibalisation look like growth.
 4. **Incrementality vs. cannibalisation.** The measurement discipline at the heart of Claim 3.
 5. **Leader vs. challenger strategy.** Explains why the same evidence justified opposite decisions.
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9. Suggested deck structure (12–14 slides)

#	Slide	Content
1	Title	The corrected question, not the original one
2	The premise, corrected	"Swiggy also failed. Zepto also retreated. Eternal may be winning round two." Hook the room immediately.

3	Timeline	All six attempts across three companies, 2022–2026, on one horizontal axis
4	The taxonomy	The four-architecture table from Section 3. Your load-bearing slide.
5	The economics	Unit economics identity + the two paths to making it work
6	The symmetry slide	Goyal's Quick quote and Swiggy's Snacc quote side by side. Both say "density."
7	Why Bolt worked	The three design constraints + the 2 km / delivery-cost mechanism + the 4–6% retention number
8	Why Bistro works	The Blinkit dark-store piggyback + "this isn't a restaurant, it's a food manufacturing system"
9	Same model, opposite verdicts	Quick vs. Bolt: the 16-week gap + the metric divergence
10	The thesis	Three claims, one line each
11	The scoreboard today	Q4FY26 / Q1FY27 numbers for both. No winner declared.
12	What I'd watch next	Bistro kitchen count, Bolt re-disclosure, Toing/Ownly/Flipkart entry
13	Limitations & data conflicts	Section 10. This slide earns more credit than you'd expect.
14	Sources	Section 11

PM note on slide 13: Most students hide their gaps. Put yours on a slide. A reviewer who spots an unacknowledged weakness marks you down; a reviewer who sees you already spotted it marks you up. It costs you 40 seconds and buys you credibility for the whole deck.

10. Limitations, conflicts, and what I could not verify

Read this section carefully. Do not present anything below as settled fact.

10.1 Conflicting data — Bolt's share of orders

Source	Period	Figure
Swiggy Q3FY25	Oct–Dec 2024	9% of food deliveries
Swiggy Q4FY25 / HSIE / MOSL	Jan–Mar 2025	12%+ of FD GOV
Rohit Kapoor, Nov 2025	—	~1 in 10 orders

The number appears to go 9% → 12% → 10%. Possible reconciliations: the metrics differ (GOV share vs. order-count share); the denominator grew substantially; or the 99-Store, launched July 2025, absorbed some of the low-AOV occasion Bolt had been serving. **Do not draw a smooth rising line.** Present the three data points with their differing definitions and note the ambiguity.

10.2 Swiggy stopped disclosing Bolt separately

From Q4FY26, Swiggy reports Bolt only bundled with One BLCK, 99-Store and Eat Right (~25% of volumes combined). **We therefore cannot isolate Bolt's current performance.** The bundling may be a simple reporting-convenience choice — or it may be masking deceleration in Bolt specifically. Note the ambiguity honestly; do not speculate on a slide about which.

10.3 Zepto Café figures are contested

ET reporting says daily orders fell from ~100k to 65–67k and that 44 locations closed. Zepto's spokesperson simultaneously claimed +700% YoY, +15% MoM and ₹1,000 crore annual net sales, and said they were doubling down. **These cannot both be straightforwardly true.** Present both, attribute both, resolve neither. Zepto is private and files no comparable public disclosures.

10.4 Attribution caution on Eternal's Q1FY27 commentary

Several outlets attribute July 2026 shareholder-letter and earnings-call remarks about Bistro to **Deepinder Goyal**, but Goyal ceased to be Group CEO on **1 February 2026** (Albinder Dhindsa succeeded him; Goyal is Vice Chairman). The remarks may be Goyal writing in his board capacity, or loose journalism. **Attribute these to "Eternal management" or "Eternal's Q1FY27 shareholder letter" rather than to Goyal-as-CEO.** Getting this wrong is the kind of avoidable error that undermines an otherwise solid deck.

10.5 The "three failures" framing has a soft edge

Zomato Everyday was a **home-style meals** service, not strictly a 10-minute product — though Eternal itself grouped it with Quick in the same shutdown announcement, and it was the direct successor to Instant. If challenged, the defensible framing is: *"three shutdowns of*

quick/convenience food initiatives, of which two carried an explicit sub-15-minute promise." Say that rather than defending a shaky "three 10-minute failures."

10.6 Bistro's success is early and unproven

38 kitchens as of mid-2025, expanding at ~10 per quarter as of mid-2026, and driving segment losses. The claim of "incremental orders without cannibalisation" is **management's own**, unaudited and not independently verified. Bistro is a promising bet, **not a proven win**. Say "working so far," never "succeeded."

10.7 What I could not find

- Bolt's standalone AOV, contribution margin, or order counts (never disclosed).
- Zomato Instant's order volumes, GOV, or losses (never disclosed).
- Any quantified consumer-sentiment comparison between the 2022 and 2024 launches.
- Restaurant-partner churn or exclusivity terms between Bolt and Quick.
- Bistro's unit-level economics or per-kitchen break-even point.

If a reviewer asks for any of these, the correct answer is "that's not publicly disclosed." Do not estimate. An honest gap beats a fabricated number every time.

11. Source list

Primary — company disclosures

- Swiggy Q4 & FY26 Shareholders' Letter, 8 May 2026 (audited) — *Snacc shutdown rationale; Q4FY26 metrics; ~25% volume share of speed/affordability propositions*
- Swiggy Q1FY26, Q2FY26, Q3FY25 Shareholders' Letters
- Swiggy press release: "Swiggy launches Bolt," 5 October 2024
- Swiggy press release: "Swiggy Expands Bolt to 400+ cities," 2 December 2024
- Eternal Q1FY26 shareholder letter (Bistro: 38 kitchens); Q2FY26 earnings call; Q1FY27 shareholder letter and earnings call
- Eternal stock exchange filings: Blinkit Foods subsidiary incorporation (Aug 2025); CEO transition (21 Jan 2026, effective 1 Feb 2026)
- Deepinder Goyal's March 2022 Zomato Instant announcement blog/LinkedIn post

Analyst coverage

- JM Financial Institutional Equities — Bolt margin non-dilutive assessment
- HDFC Securities (HSIE) — Swiggy Q4FY25 Results Review, 12 May 2025
- Motilal Oswal — Swiggy Q4FY25 note
- Bernstein — Swiggy initiation, January 2025; 2022 commentary on 10-min viability

- ICICI Securities — Q1FY26 quick-commerce market share

Business press

- TechCrunch — Zomato Instant launch (21 Mar 2022); Bolt launch (Oct 2024); Bolt 400-city expansion (2 Dec 2024)
- Business Standard — Instant shutdown (Jan 2023); Swiggy/Eternal quarterly coverage; Eternal vs Swiggy comparison (4 Aug 2026); CEO transition
- Reuters / Deccan Herald — Zomato Instant backlash coverage, March 2022
- Business Today — operational critique of 10-min feasibility (Sept 2022); Bolt launch
- Medianama — Eternal Q2FY26 and Q1FY27 earnings-call takeaways; Swiggy Q4FY25 and Q4FY26 analyses; Zomato Now vending pods (Aug 2026)
- Inc42 — Quick and Everyday shutdown (May 2025); Zepto Café scale-down
- Outlook Business — "Why Swiggy Is Still Betting on Bolt While Zomato Walks Away" (May 2025); "Zomato, Zepto Walk Away from 10-Minute Food Delivery" (July 2025)
- Economic Times (via secondary reporting) — Zepto Café order decline; Zomato Now
- OfficeChai — Goyal's Quick shutdown quotes
- YourStory — Zomato Quick restaurant-partner outreach (Harsukh Foods)

Academic / research

- Emerald Emerging Markets Case Studies — "*Zomato.com: 10-min delivery*" (DOI: 10.1108/EEMCS-04-2023-0095). **Read this one.** It is a peer-reviewed teaching case on exactly your topic and will give you framing language and citable academic grounding.
- Fairwork India — gig economy ratings, 2019–2021
- Swiggy × Kearney, "*How India Eats*" report, November 2025

PM note on sourcing: Prioritise the shareholder letters over the press. Press coverage paraphrases; shareholder letters are the company's own words under regulatory obligation. Where they conflict, the filing wins. And when you quote a CEO, quote the letter, not the article about the letter.

12. If you want to go further

Four things that would meaningfully strengthen this, in order of return on effort:

1. **Read the Emerald case study** (Section 11). It's peer-reviewed, on exactly this topic, and will let you cite academic framing rather than only press.
2. **Pull the Q4FY26 and Q1FY27 earnings call transcripts** for both companies and search for "Bolt" and "Bistro." Analyst Q&A is where management gets pushed off script — the most useful admissions live there, not in the prepared letters.

3. **Do a 30-minute app teardown.** Open both apps. Where does Bolt sit in Swiggy's information architecture? Does Bistro have its own app, a Blinkit tab, or both? Placement in the nav is a real signal of internal priority, and it's original research nobody else in your cohort will have.
4. **Check whether Bistro's kitchen count has moved since July 2026.** It's the live variable in this entire story. If it accelerates past ~10/quarter, Eternal has validated Model D and your closing slide gets sharper.

Prepared 25 August 2026. All figures sourced. Sections 10.1–10.7 flag every known conflict and gap — do not present around them, present them.